

The Birmingham First-Home Checklist

For buying new construction in the Birmingham metro. Every box is a question the sales office will answer if you ask. Most people do not ask.

BEFORE YOU TOUR

- ☐ Get a pre-approval letter before you walk a model. Not after you fall in love with one.
 - ☐ Write down your real monthly ceiling, including taxes, insurance and HOA. Bring it with you.
 - ☐ Decide who represents you. The person at the model desk works for the builder. That is their job, and they are good at it.
 - ☐ Ask me to register with the builder as your agent before your first visit. Most builders will not add me afterwards.
-

AT THE MODEL HOME

- ☐ Which plan is this model, and which plan does the "starting at" price buy? They are usually not the same house.
- ☐ Which finishes in this room are standard, and which are upgrades? Ask for the standard-features sheet in writing.
- ☐ Which lots are available right now, and what is the lot premium on each one?
- ☐ Is this house standing, framed, or dirt on the ground? Take a photo of the plaque or the window sticker with the date.
- ☐ If the house is still going up, do not ask when it will be finished. Ask what is left. Drywall and paint means close. Waiting on cabinets does not.
- ☐ Does the plan page match the plan sheet? Count the garage bays on both. I have seen them disagree.
- ☐ If the sector name on the flyer and the name on the site plan differ, ask which one the contract will say.

Why that matters: at Walker Springs in Alabaster, a sector drawn as "The Ridge" on the engineer's site plan had been renamed The Reserve by hand on the drawing. Source: InSite Engineering site plan, read 31 Aug 2026.

THE PRICE

- ☐ A price on a flyer is a list price. Say "listed at" in your own head. The house next door may have closed for something else.

- ☐ Ask what the last three houses in this community actually closed for. That number is public. I can pull it.
 - ☐ Ask what incentives are on offer this month, and whether they are tied to using the builder's lender.
 - ☐ Ask what the HOA costs today and what it is projected to cost once the community is built out.
-

PROPERTY TAX: THE QUIET ONE

- ☐ Ask whether the monthly payment you were quoted uses the tax on the finished house or the tax on the lot.
- ☐ Look the lot up yourself on the county tax site. If it has no tax record of its own yet, the quote was built on dirt.
- ☐ Plan for the escrow to be re-figured after the first full assessment. It usually goes up, not down.

A real example, with the record: the three Riviera Run lots I photographed at Walker Springs had no tax record of their own for 2025 or 2026. The county taxed the 6.1-acre tract under them as bare land, \$1,146.96 for the whole tract. A house appraised at its \$555,900 list price at Alabama's 10% Class III ratio and that tract's 54.0 mills works out to roughly \$3,002 a year before any homestead exemption. That is an estimate, and it is labeled as one. Sources: Shelby County Property Tax Commissioner portal, parcels 23 6 24 3 301 003.007 / 004.000 / 007.000 / 023.000, pulled 10 Sep 2026; Alabama Department of Revenue assessment ratio; Newcastle Homes plaque and flyer, 30 Jul 2026.

LENDING

- ☐ You'll definitely want to ask me about their lending options before you sign anything.
 - ☐ Get the builder lender's full quote in writing and let one outside lender see it. Same day. No cost to you.
 - ☐ Ask what happens to the incentive if the builder's lender cannot close on time.
-

BEFORE YOU SIGN

- ☐ Read the spec line on the contract. It names the plan, the lot, and the elevation. Make sure it is the house you walked.
- ☐ Ask for the list of every selection you have made, with prices, as an addendum.
- ☐ Ask what the earnest money is, when it stops being refundable, and what the builder's own cancellation terms are.
- ☐ Hire your own inspector for the pre-drywall walk and the final walk. New does not mean finished.
- ☐ Ask what the warranty covers in year one, year two, and year ten, and who you call.

WHEN YOU HAVE YOUR ANSWERS

Send me the plan, the lot, and the quote. I will tell you what I see. No charge for looking, and I do not get paid unless you close. Text or call 205-615-4316, or reply to the email this came with.

Nicholas Santiago · Licensed Real Estate Salesperson · eXp Realty · Alabama · Equal Housing Opportunity
New Homes of Birmingham · followthenicholas@gmail.com · 205-615-4316. This checklist is general information, not legal, tax or lending advice. Every figure above names its source and date; nothing is promised about price, approval or appreciation.